

tissue culture laboratory on his farm. He revolutionised traditional seed potato production by isolating disease-free clones of potato varieties and laid the ground for rapid multiplication of seedlings, raising annual production by 15 to 20 per cent. Sangha regularly travels across the globe attending international conferences and has leveraged his American exposure to forge tie-ups with MNCs. Of late, he has been exploring new markets like Pakistan. As for agriculture in Punjab, "it urgently needs to diversify into specialty crops," says Sangha, "But that will happen only if there is supporting infrastructure and sure-footed marketing." With trailblazers like Sangha in the forefront, the powers-that-be are sure to pay heed.



■ By Amitabh Srivastava

MARRIAGE MARTS

Patna | BIHAR



Aligning the stars

In an India that moves freely across castes and communities, matches are still made in bureaus that follow prescribed norms

Mohammed Hussain—the affable clean-shaven matchmaker—has just returned from a sun-baked dusty village in Bihar's Begusarai district. He was there to counsel a Patna girl who was determined to storm out of her four-year-marriage. "The Patna girl in fact was finding it difficult to adjust to the village backwaters," says Hussain. But a Hussain session later, the vows were repeated, and a marriage which was on the rocks a day before, stood redeemed.

Mission accomplished for Hussain, the part-time counsellor, who does not charge for the "social service." Such sessions, however, let Hussain earn brownie points which come in handy for fixing marriages, his first love. Photographs of the trophies—his success stories—line the

wall. Carefully circled matrimonial classifieds lie scattered around the table. This thirty nine-year-old post graduate in geography could have pursued a more conventional career. Instead, he opted to set up a marriage bureau, Hamsafar Marriage International. It is now one of the oldest marriage bureaus in Patna, with over 10,000 registered clients.

But it is not the only player in the field. It faces stiff competition with over 30 marriage bureaus in Patna alone. Charges vary from

Rs 501 to Rs 5,001, without guarantee certificates, so the bureau cannot be crucified if the union fails. Whether it is questions on the groom's salary, CAT scores or dowry demands—Hussain is the friendly broker who fixes earthly alliances and aligns the stars. Upper class officers and businessmen are still considered good catches. "Biharis are still not comfortable with the Internet," says Hussain. "That's where the personal touch scores over marriage websites," he says.

